Spec Sheet: Design — Visual & Textual Communication

Module Identity

- **Title:** Design (working title — "Design: Visual & Textual Communication")
- **Type:** Interactive classroom activity (dialogue-bd.com style — QR join, projection-optimized)
- **Audience:** PSDP students / English club learners
- **Status:** REPLACES the "English for Freelancers — Graphic Design" spec (2026-10-13). The graphic-design-only frame is superseded.
- **Pedagogy:** Every design element and principle is taught twice — once visually, once textually — always paired side by side. The principle of proximity links them in the learner's mind: visual and textual are never separated, so the learner experiences them as one discipline.
- **Design rule:** Integration over isolation — every pairing teaches visual and textual together, never separated.
- **Payoff:** design literacy + English writing skill. The durable skill: seeing all communication as designed.

Central Thesis

Design = visual communication = textual communication. Both are the arrangement of elements according to principles. A paragraph is a layout. A sentence has balance. Word choice is color. The designer who sees this works in two mediums at once.

The 15 Pairings

Each pairing: (a) the visual concept taught through comprehensible input (tap-to-reveal, the word IS its definition), (b) the textual equivalent.

ELEMENTS (7)

1. Line → Sentence

- Visual: line quality — thick/thin, straight/curved, solid/dashed; lines structure, frame, divide, guide the eye.
- Textual: the sentence is the line of prose. Sentence variety (short/long, simple/complex) is line-weight variation. A wall of uniform sentences is a wall of identical lines — monotonous.
- Note: We even intuitively understand the metaphor when we say things like "That was a good line" when referring to a sentence.

2. Color → Diction

- Visual: hue, saturation, temperature; warm/cool; color creates mood.
- Textual: word choice is color. Adjectives especially — vivid vs muted, warm vs cold diction. Connotation is color temperature ("slim" vs "skinny" is a hue shift).

3. Shape → Text shapes

- Visual: geometric vs organic shapes; shapes defined by boundaries.
- Textual: sentence shapes, paragraph shapes, story arcs — the shape of a narrative (rise/fall, circle back). Structured vs flowing prose.

4. Texture → Sound & rhythm

- Visual: surface quality — rough/smooth, dense/air; texture creates feel.
- Textual: the sound of prose — alliteration, assonance, cadence. Dense vs airy writing. Read aloud: clunky is rough, flowing is smooth.

5. Form → Subtext

- Visual: 3D — what exists under/behind the surface; depth.
- Textual: subtext — what's implied but not stated. The meaning under the words. (High-context resonance: Bangladeshi communicators already design with subtext.)

6. Space → Silence

- Visual: negative space — what you leave out gives meaning to what remains.
- Textual: paragraph breaks, line breaks, strategic omission. What's deliberately unsaid. Short paragraphs are whitespace.

7. Typography → Emphasis & voice

- Visual: typeface personality, weight, formatting as meaning.
- Textual: bold/italic as vocal stress; register as typeface personality (formal = serif, casual = sans). Formatting choices carry meaning.

PRINCIPLES (8)

8. Contrast → Antithesis & juxtaposition

- Visual: big/small, dark/light, difference creates emphasis.
- Textual: "best of times, worst of times." A short sentence detonating after a long one. Concrete against abstract.

9. Hierarchy → Information architecture

- Visual: scale, weight, position guide the eye to what's most important.
- Textual: thesis → topic sentences → evidence. Headings. Inverted pyramid, BLUF (bottom line up front).

10. Alignment → Parallelism

- Visual: edges line up; misalignment creates unease.
- Textual: parallel structure ("of the people, by the people, for the people"). Consistent tense, consistent terms. Misaligned grammar feels like crooked boxes.

11. Balance → Punctuation & sentence architecture

- Visual: symmetrical (formal), asymmetrical (dynamic), radial.
- Textual: the semicolon IS symmetrical balance — two independent clauses of equal weight in equilibrium. The em-dash is asymmetrical — interruption throwing weight to one side. Periodic sentences (main clause delayed = tension) vs loose sentences (main clause first = ease).

12. Proximity → Paragraphing & cohesion *(the meta-principle)*

- Visual: related items grouped; distance signals separation.
- Textual: paragraphing — related ideas share a paragraph, breaks signal distance. Cohesive devices (however, moreover, this) as glue.
- Meta: this module itself runs on proximity — visual and textual always side by side, so the learner's mind fuses them.

13. Repetition → Anaphora, refrain, inclusio

- Visual: repeating elements create unity and rhythm.
- Textual: anaphora ("I have a dream"), refrains, inclusio (bookending — open and close with the same phrase), lexical chains.

14. Simplicity → Concision

- Visual: remove the unnecessary; every element earns its place.
- Textual: "omit needless words." Plain language. Kill throat-clearing ("in today's modern world").

15. Function → Genre & purpose

- Visual: form follows function; design serves its job.
- Textual: a CV, a story, and an essay are different forms because they do different jobs. "What is this text FOR?" is the design brief.

UX Design

Entry toggle: at the start, the learner chooses "I'm interested in visual communication" or "I'm interested in written communication." The choice determines the UI:

- **Visual path:** a very graphical homepage with minimal text. Click a design principle or graphic element → paired lesson with its writing twin.
- **Textual path:** a very textual, writing-focused UI. Click "sentence" → paired lesson with graphic design "line."
- Different coach mascots per path.
- The lesson core is shared; the entry layer differs.

Mobile: side-by-side pairing cards don't fit narrow screens — interleave the two focuses in a single scroll (visual → textual → visual). Alternation forces re-encoding in the other medium; not a degraded layout.

Sequence: hub entry (learner-chosen via toggle), recommended sequence within (elements before principles — principles operate on elements).

Unit structure (each of the 15 pairings):

1. **Comprehensible input** — ESL-friendly vocab session teaching examples of the element/principle in the entry domain (visual examples on the visual path, textual on the textual path). Tap-to-reveal, word-IS-definition style.
2. **Meaning negotiation** — dialogue or visual motion graphic showing cause and effect: change the diction, watch the mood shift; change the layout, watch the hierarchy collapse. The learner works with the meaning, not just receives it.

Cross-description (core technique): use words to describe graphic design, and graphics to describe written design.

- Describe a logo's balance *in words* → precise design vocabulary + observational writing.
- *Draw* the shape of a paragraph (ex for inspiration: https://bibleproject.com/videos/psalm-1/), color-code a sentence by clause, diagram an essay's hierarchy → structural reading comprehension that doesn't look like a test.
- Each medium becomes the analytical tool for the other. Unfakeable in both directions.

Source Material

- Tim's 37 comprehensible-input slides (visual side of each pairing)
- Gareth David guides (theory spine — now read as design theory, not just graphic design theory)
- Famous brand logos + ESL worksheet (visual analysis; pair with textual analysis exercises)
- Pixar in a Box: lighting/color/perspective/shape language/culture (feeds pairings 2, 5, and the visual side generally)

- **NEW NEED:** textual example bank — antithesis examples, parallelism examples, inclusio examples, punctuation-as-balance demonstrations. To be curated.

Interactions

- Side-by-side pairing cards: visual left, textual right (proximity as pedagogy), tap to reveal each
- The 15 tap-to-reveal vocabulary interactions (from the prototype — keep)
- "Redesign this" exercises: given a weak paragraph, apply a principle (e.g., "add hierarchy," "cut for simplicity") and compare before/after
- Spot-the-problem quizzes (visual AND textual flaws)
- Contrast checker, palette lab, shape language demo (from the prototype — keep)
- Cross-description exercises: describe-the-visual-in-words prompts; draw-the-text-as-graphics prompts

Open Questions

1. Title? Options: "Design: Visual & Textual," "The Design Module," "Design Is Design."
2. The ChatGPT handoff package (`workspace/graphic-design-module-handoff.zip`) is scoped to the OLD frame. Update or leave?
3. Textual example bank: curate from real sources (speeches, literature) or write originals?
4. Mascot design: two coaches (one per path) or one shared? Two doubles the art cost.